NATIVE, THE COMPASS, EXPLAINED WITH ONE GOAL

One goal, many subgoals

How one line of intent becomes work a company can run, check, and improve. Told with one small loan.



Draft for the founder's read, 2026-10-12. The example is a lending company.

START

The goal, in one line

A goal is only a goal when you can say how you would know it is done.

THE GOAL

Give one customer a small personal loan.

HOW WE KNOW IT IS DONE

The money is in the customer's account within 2 working days, and every step is on record.

One goal, one check. Every piece we cut from it will carry the same two things.

THE METHOD

How to cut a goal, in three rules

The same three rules at every size: a company, a department, one loan.

1

Ask one question of the goal, and cut along the answer.

"What pieces does it have?" gives pieces. "When?" gives phases.

2

Every piece gets one goal and one check.

Stop cutting when a piece cannot be split and still be work. That piece is a **work atom**.

3

Add the next question. The pieces become a grid.

New questions do not add pieces. They add readings to the pieces you have.

In Native the questions are called axes, and the axes come in six families: the compass.

THE COMPASS

Six questions you can ask of any piece of work

Six families. Every question you could ask of work belongs to one of them. We will ask them one at a time.

SHAPE

What pieces does it have?

Read fresh from this goal, every time. A different goal gets a different cut.

TIME

When, and by when?

Which phase each piece lives in, and the clock it must beat.

EDGE

Who hands what to whom?

The links between pieces. Where work waits, and where it gets stuck.

GOVERN

May it go on its own?

Auto, ask, or deny. Who stamps, before the run, so nobody is surprised.

RESOURCE

What does it spend?

Minutes of a person, calls of the system, money. A finite stock.

GROW

What has the record taught?

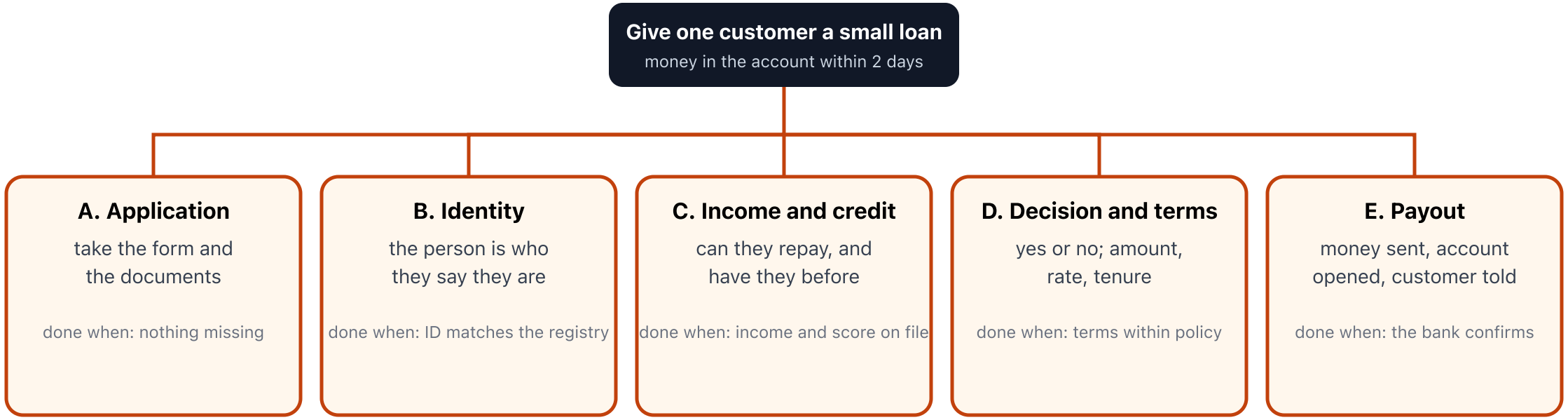
Across many runs: what repeats becomes a rule, a template, or code.

We start with SHAPE and TIME, the two anyone can draw on paper. They alone make the goal runnable.

QUESTION 1 OF 6, SHAPE

What pieces does the goal have?

Cut along the natural seams. Five pieces, each with its own check. This is the cut a branch manager would draw on a whiteboard.



Each box is still too big to run: "Identity" is several actions. The next question splits them without inventing new pieces.

QUESTION 2 OF 6, TIME

When does each piece happen, and by when?

Cross the five pieces with four phases. The pieces become a grid of **subgoals**. Empty cells are honest: no work lives there.

	1. Apply day 0	2. Check within 4 hours	3. Decide within 1 working day	4. Pay out within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** done when: form complete, 3 documents in	**A2. Ask for anything missing** done when: the missing item named, customer told	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** done when: a readable ID on file	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** done when: match confirmed, or mismatch named	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** done when: 6 months on file	**C2. Read the statements, pull the credit score** done when: income and score on file, or a reason	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** done when: terms within policy	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** done when: agreement matches the terms	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** done when: the bank confirms the credit

11 subgoals, 9 empty cells. Two questions were enough to make the goal runnable.

QUESTION 3 OF 6, EDGE

Who does each subgoal, and who hands to whom?

Same grid. One reading added, highlighted; what we already had is grayed out. Every border between two colours is a hand-off.

	1. Apply day 0	2. Check within 4 hours	3. Decide within 1 working day	4. Pay out within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** done when: form complete, 3 documents in officer	**A2. Ask for anything missing** done when: the missing item named, customer told officer	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** done when: a readable ID on file customer	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** done when: match confirmed, or mismatch named system	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** done when: 6 months on file customer	**C2. Read the statements, pull the credit score** done when: income and score on file, or a reason system	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** done when: terms within policy credit desk	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** done when: agreement matches the terms system	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** done when: the bank confirms the credit finance

customer · branch officer · the system · credit desk · finance

4 hand-offs: customer to officer, officer to system, system to credit desk, credit desk to finance

EDGE reads the link between two subgoals, never the subgoal itself. Four links, four places work can wait.

QUESTION 4 OF 6, GOVERN

May this subgoal go on its own, or must someone stamp it?

Most cells run on their own. Two cells ask for a stamp. One cell can stop the whole goal.

	1. Apply day 0	2. Check within 4 hours	3. Decide within 1 working day	4. Pay out within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** done when: form complete, 3 documents in officer · auto	**A2. Ask for anything missing** done when: the missing item named, customer told officer · auto	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** done when: a readable ID on file customer · auto	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** done when: match confirmed, or mismatch named system · deny	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** done when: 6 months on file customer · auto	**C2. Read the statements, pull the credit score** done when: income and score on file, or a reason system · auto	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** done when: terms within policy credit desk · ask	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** done when: agreement matches the terms system · auto	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** done when: the bank confirms the credit finance · ask

auto: runs on its own ask: a person stamps first deny: the goal stops here if the check fails

The stamps are known before the run. Nobody is surprised by an ask, and nothing leaves the record without one.

QUESTION 5 OF 6, RESOURCE

What does each subgoal spend?

Two numbers per cell: minutes of a person and calls of the system. Now the goal has a cost, and the cost can be read back after every run.

	1. Apply day 0	2. Check within 4 hours	3. Decide within 1 working day	4. Pay out within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	A1. Take the form and the documents officer · auto **4 min, 1 call**	A2. Ask for anything missing officer · auto **2 min, 1 call**	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	B1. Customer uploads an ID customer · auto **0 min, 0 calls**	B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry system · deny **0 min, 2 calls**	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	C1. Customer gives bank statements customer · auto **0 min, 0 calls**	C2. Read the statements, pull the credit score system · auto **0 min, 6 calls**	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure credit desk · ask **8 min, 1 call**	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	E3. Draft the agreement system · auto **0 min, 2 calls**	E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer finance · ask **5 min, 1 call**

One run: 22 person-minutes, 14 system calls, 2 working days. The scarcest stock is a person's attention; the two asks are where it goes. Illustrative numbers; in a live department they come from the record.

QUESTION 6 OF 6, GROW

After 40 loans, what has the record taught?

GROW does not cut. It reads the 40 runs and lifts what repeated into a rule, a template, or a step frozen to code.

	1. Apply day 0	2. Check within 4 hours	3. Decide within 1 working day	4. Pay out within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	A1. Take the form and the documents officer · auto 4 min, 1 call	A2. Ask for anything missing officer · auto 2 min, 1 call **template learned: the missing-document ask**	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	B1. Customer uploads an ID customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry system · deny 0 min, 2 calls	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	C1. Customer gives bank statements customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	C2. Read the statements, pull the credit score system · auto 0 min, 6 calls	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure credit desk · ask 8 min, 1 call **rule learned: under 1 lakh with score above 750 goes auto**	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	E3. Draft the agreement system · auto 0 min, 2 calls	E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer finance · ask 5 min, 1 call

frozen to code: same result 40 of 40 times, now near free · warm: the system does it, a person watches · hot: a person decides every time

First run expensive, every run cheaper. Not a hope: the grid records every cell, and GROW reads the record.

ALL SIX AT ONCE

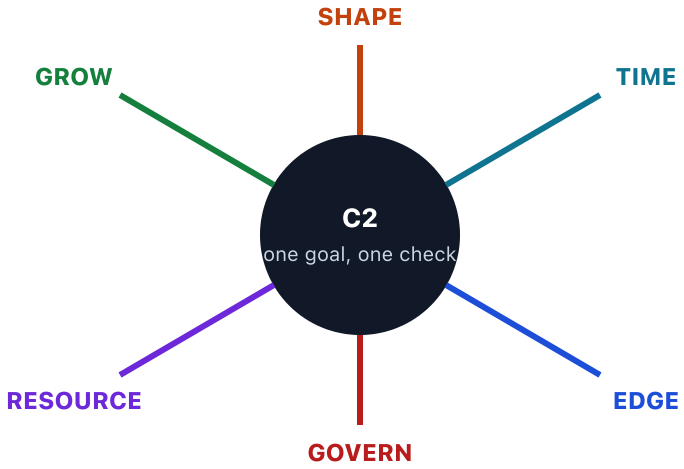
One subgoal, six readings

Take one cell: "read the bank statements and pull the credit score". It is not six things. It is one thing, read six ways, on every run.

SUBGOAL C2

Read the bank statements, pull the credit score.

done when: 6 months of income on file and a score, or a named reason why not



SHAPE

a piece of "Income and credit"; the ground is not simple, so the system looks closer rather than rushing

TIME

phase 2 of 4; within 4 hours of the documents arriving

EDGE

receives the statements from the customer; hands income and score to the decision

GOVERN

auto; stops the goal if no score can be pulled; a person never reads raw statements unless this cell asks

RESOURCE

0 person-minutes, 6 system calls; the costliest cell until it freezes

GROW

warm after 40 runs; steady for salaried customers, so a split is proposed: salaried freezes, self-employed stays warm

Every cell on every grid carries these six readings. That is the whole compass, applied.

THE WHOLE COMPASS ON ONE GOAL

SHAPE TIME EDGE GOVERN RESOURCE GROW

The grid, with every reading on

What the system sees for one small loan: five pieces, four phases, eleven subgoals, six readings each.

	1. Apply day 0	2. Check within 4 hours	3. Decide within 1 working day	4. Pay out within 2 working days
A. Application take the form and documents	**A1. Take the form and the documents** done when: form complete, 3 documents in officer · auto 4 min, 1 call	**A2. Ask for anything missing** done when: the missing item named, customer told officer · auto 2 min, 1 call	no work here	no work here
B. Identity the person is who they say	**B1. Customer uploads an ID** done when: a readable ID on file customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	**B2. Match the ID to the photo and the registry** done when: match confirmed, or mismatch named system · deny 0 min, 2 calls	no work here	no work here
C. Income and credit can they repay	**C1. Customer gives bank statements** done when: 6 months on file customer · auto 0 min, 0 calls	**C2. Read the statements, pull the credit score** done when: income and score on file, or a reason system · auto 0 min, 6 calls	no work here	no work here
D. Decision and terms yes or no, and on what terms	no work here	no work here	**D3. Compare with policy; set amount, rate, tenure** done when: terms within policy credit desk · ask 8 min, 1 call	no work here
E. Payout money sent, account opened	no work here	no work here	**E3. Draft the agreement** done when: agreement matches the terms system · auto 0 min, 2 calls	**E4. Send the money, open the account, tell the customer** done when: the bank confirms the credit finance · ask 5 min, 1 call

One line from the owner became this. The owner only wrote the line and stamped two asks.

DO IT YOURSELF

Cut any goal in five moves

1. **Write the goal in one line, with its check.**
   If you cannot say how you would know it is done, it is a wish, not a goal.

2. **Ask SHAPE: what pieces?**
   Follow the seams. One goal and one check per piece. Stop at the work atom.

3. **Ask TIME: when?**
   Put each piece in its phase. Leave empty cells empty.

4. **Add one reading at a time.**
   EDGE: who hands to whom. GOVERN: auto, ask, deny. RESOURCE: what it spends.

5. **Run it, and let GROW change the next cut.**
   A step that never varies freezes to code. A stamp given the same way ten times becomes a rule. A pain that repeats grows a new rule of its own.

WHY TWO QUESTIONS FIRST

SHAPE and TIME are the two anyone can draw. They make the goal runnable on their own. The other four add readings, not pieces.

WHY SIX, AND WHY THEY DO NOT CHANGE

Every question you can ask of work sorts into one family. New questions are added freely inside a family. The six stay.

THE PROMISE

First run expensive, every run cheaper, because the grid records every cell and GROW reads the record.

IN ONE SENTENCE

A company is work. Every piece of work can be asked six questions. The system asks them on every run, writes the answers to the record, and the record makes the next run cheaper.

The owner writes one line and stamps the asks. Everything else is the compass at work.

Source: Native, the compass (axes and families), and the department page, "one workflow read along five axes". Draft, 2026-10-12.